

The Psychology of Gratitude: Implications for Organizations

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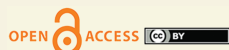
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Keywords

gratitude, positive emotion, workplace relationships, well-being, positive
organizational scholarship, helping behavior

Abstract

In this review, we distill existing research on gratitude and its role in organizations. We begin by examining how gratitude is conceptualized and defined, considering its manifestations as an emotion, an expression, and a feature of a collective. We next develop a model arguing that gratitude is best understood as a phenomenon that begins within the self but has the potential to cascade beyond the self and emerge at higher levels of analysis. After reviewing the key theories that underpin gratitude scholarship, we explore existing research on gratitude's functions. We follow with a consideration of gratitude's antecedents. Finally, we conclude with a discussion of promising trajectories for future research, emphasizing important directions for both theory and practice.

INTRODUCTION

Once confined to philosophy, theology, and related disciplines, gratitude has witnessed a flood of empirical research in the social sciences in recent decades. Psychologists have demonstrated a particularly sustained interest in the construct throughout the twenty-first century. Their efforts have produced a science of gratitude that continues to grow in explanatory power and nuance (Algoe 2012, Ma et al. 2017, McCullough et al. 2001). Theories and frameworks such as find-remind-bind theory (Algoe 2012), the Emotions as Social Information (EASI) model (Van Kleef 2009), and functionalist accounts of emotion (Keltner & Haidt 1999) have provided scholars with the scaffolding needed to help the literature move forward.

While slower to develop, organizational research on gratitude also has seen a striking uptick in recent years. Scholars have explored how gratitude impacts outcomes such as trust, voice, helping behavior, and team creativity, and they have traced its antecedents to workplace constructs such as servant leadership and team climate (Dunn & Schweitzer 2005, Fehr et al. 2017, Locklear et al. 2023, Pillay et al. 2020, Spence et al. 2014).

To date, research consistently underscores the many ways in which gratitude benefits employees, relationships, and collectives, thereby bringing tremendous value to organizations. In line with this growing evidence base, a wide array of organizations, ranging from nonprofits to Fortune 500 companies, have aspired to cultivate cultures of gratitude within their workplaces (Newman 2017). The purpose of this review is to build clarity around the literature on gratitude in organizations and, in doing so, help researchers identify fruitful paths for future research. We begin by examining the conceptual landscape of gratitude, differentiating among felt, expressed, and collective gratitude. Then, we review the theoretical underpinnings of gratitude. We discuss theories, such as find-remind-bind theory, that have proved particularly influential and use them to guide and shape our subsequent discussion of gratitude's nomological net. We subsequently examine gratitude's functions and antecedents. For each of these discussions, we highlight its implications for organizations (summarized in **Table 1**). Finally, we end by discussing important considerations for future research.

As a starting point for our review, we collected every article written in the past 20 years on gratitude or appreciation in a select group of top outlets in organizational behavior and psychology (e.g., *Journal of Applied Psychology*, *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*). Then, we expanded our scope to include highly cited papers in additional high-quality outlets (e.g., *Emotion*). We focus primarily on studies conducted in organizations or with the organizational context in mind.

Table 1 Implications of existing work for organizational research

Domain of existing work	Implications for organizational research
Defining gratitude	Clear definitions beyond the individual level are needed to fully understand gratitude's role in organizations. New theorizing is needed to examine the distribution of gratitude in collectives.
Theories of and for gratitude	Existing theories offer a useful framework for felt gratitude and, to a lesser extent, expressed and received gratitude. New theorizing is needed to properly embed gratitude research in the organizational sciences and leverage unique features of the organizational context.
Functions of gratitude	The prosocial effects of gratitude in organizations are well-documented and well-understood. Additional work is needed to capture the nuances of gratitude's effects, including its contextual moderators, functions across levels of analysis, and cultural contingencies.
Antecedents of gratitude	Existing research typically focuses on gratitude as the consequence of received help. Interventions in particular must be sensitive to the challenge of trying to encourage gratitude in contexts dominated by transactional and competitive mindsets.

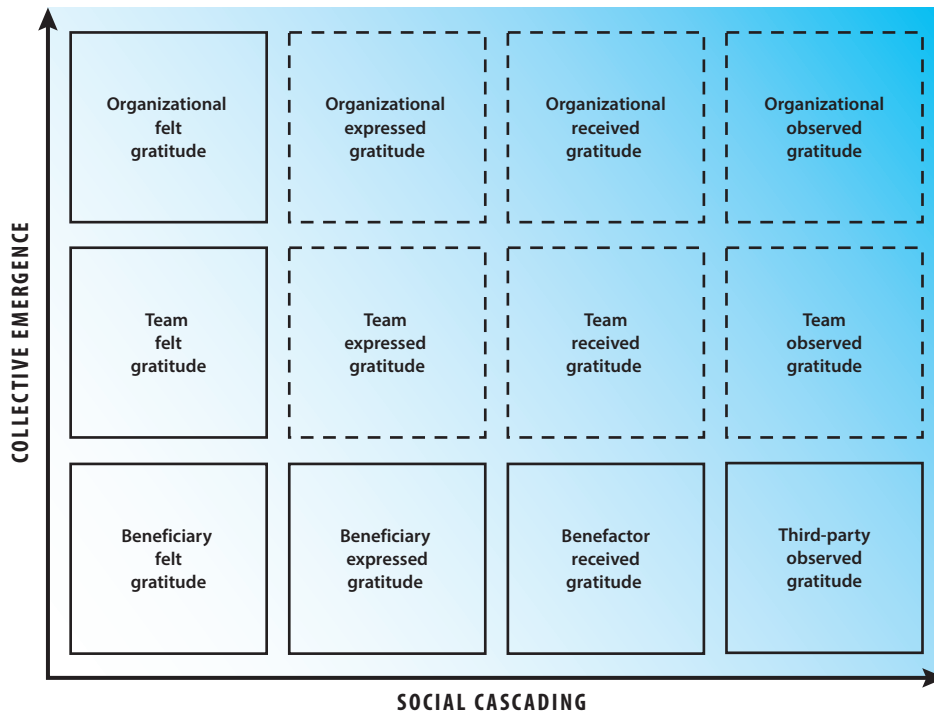


Figure 1

Gratitude's conceptual landscape. Note that the dashed lines and blue color indicate conceptual domains that have received less research attention. The vertical axis denotes the collective emergence of gratitude. The horizontal axis denotes the social cascading of gratitude.

However, we also discuss studies conducted in the broader psychology literature when focused on key theories and relevant to our understanding of gratitude in relation to organizational dynamics. Our review is guided by the social cascading and collective emergence framework (**Figure 1**), which we detail next.

DEFINING AND CONCEPTUALIZING GRATITUDE

As shown in **Figure 1**, we argue that gratitude in organizations is best understood as a multi-faceted phenomenon that moves from an internal experience to an external one that shapes the perceptions and behaviors of beneficiaries, benefactors, and observers alike. In this model, gratitude begins with the individual's emotional experience, labeled as "beneficiary felt gratitude" in our figure. It then cascades beyond the self through its expression by beneficiaries, its receipt by benefactors, and its observation by third parties. When the emotion is felt, expressed, or observed by another individual, the cascade occurs at the individual level of analysis. However, across this cascade, gratitude and its effects can also emerge at higher levels of analysis, such as when the experience, expression, or observation of gratitude becomes shared among team members. Very limited research has explored gratitude as it cascades outward at higher levels of analysis. This is reflected by the dashed boxes and progressively darker shading of **Figure 1**, indicating areas of reduced research focus. This model of social cascades and collective emergence is particularly important to building an organizational science of gratitude. Given gratitude research's stronghold in psychology, it is perhaps no surprise that the bulk of gratitude scholarship focuses on individuals'

internal experiences. However, organizational scholars stand to make a particularly meaningful contribution to the field by focusing on what happens when gratitude moves outside of the self, impacting the relational fabric of the organizations to which employees belong. Accordingly, we begin with the core of our model and expand outward and upward.

Felt Gratitude Defined

At the center of our model is the emotion of gratitude, defined as a feeling of appreciation for outcomes that benefit but arise from outside the self. Research in psychology has noted that gratitude can be directed toward many entities. Typically, gratitude is directed toward a benefactor—a person who in some way helped the individual who is feeling grateful. But gratitude also can be directed toward larger entities, such as one's group, organization, or country. For example, one paper in the organizational literature examined feelings of gratitude toward one's organization, demonstrating that organization-directed gratitude shapes how employees see their relationship with the organization and act within that relationship (Ng 2016; see also Cain et al. 2019). Research also has shown that gratitude can arise without reference to a specific benefactor, such as when one feels a sense of appreciation for their circumstances in life or existence itself, and has given this phenomenon the label of generalized gratitude (Lambert et al. 2009).

Felt gratitude can exist at varying levels of stability. Sometimes, research employs experimental or diary designs that focus on momentary feelings of gratitude (Sawyer et al. 2022). Other studies look at more stable tendencies to feel gratitude over intermediate time frames, such as over an entire day (Sun et al. 2019). Theoretical work on gratitude in organizations has proposed the notion of persistent gratitude to capture the tendency to feel gratitude in a given organization or role (Fehr et al. 2017). At the most stable level, studies of trait gratitude operationalize gratitude as a tendency to feel grateful emotions across contexts (Li et al. 2022). The most commonly used trait gratitude scale asks, for instance, the extent to which a person is "grateful to a wide variety of people" (McCullough et al. 2002, p. 127).

Organizational scholars have taken care to differentiate felt gratitude from other positive emotions such as pride, joy, and compassion (Greenbaum et al. 2020, Hu & Kaplan 2015). The literature also has demonstrated gratitude's distinction from general positive affective states (Pillay et al. 2020, Spence et al. 2014) and the notion of indebtedness (Watkins et al. 2006). These efforts show that felt gratitude in the workplace is a distinct emotional experience, just as it is outside the workplace (McCullough et al. 2001).

Expressed Gratitude Defined

When gratitude is expressed, it extends our model beyond the self to influence interpersonal dynamics. Gratitude expression can be defined as a show of appreciation for a benefactor. Whereas gratitude expression is central to historical and philosophical treatments of gratitude (Leithart 2014), it has received less attention in the social sciences relative to felt gratitude. Inasmuch as work is a fundamentally social endeavor, we argue that gratitude expression is a particularly important instantiation of gratitude for organizational scholars.

Note that our definition does not take a stance on the specifics of what is said or done to constitute a gratitude expression. It is, in this sense, socially constructed. Gratitude expression is typically conceptualized as a verbal act in the organizational literature. However, nonverbal expressions of gratitude have been explored outside the organizational context (Chang & Algoe 2020). A gratitude expression can be said to have occurred when a person believes that they expressed gratitude or when a recipient perceives that they have received an expression of gratitude. Thus, as illustrated in the lower row of **Figure 1**, expressed gratitude can be examined in three distinct ways based upon the focal person in question. It represents an experience for the person

who expresses it, an experience for the person who receives it, and, in applicable instances, an experience for anyone who observes it. These diverse focal points imply diverse considerations of antecedents, consequences, and contextual moderators. Whereas a study of gratitude expression from the beneficiary's perspective might focus on the beneficiary's motivations, a focus on the benefactor's perspective might consider how depleted or distracted the benefactor is when gratitude is offered. As another example, a focus on third-party observation might examine the observer's relationship with the benefactor or beneficiary. A single act of gratitude expression from an employee to a leader could be experienced as calming for the expresser, fulfilling for the recipient, and a sign of the expresser's warmth by a friendly observer. Another could instead be experienced as a moment of anxiety by the expresser, ignored completely by a distracted recipient, and viewed as an act of obsequiousness by a cynical observer.

As with felt gratitude, gratitude expression can be conceptualized at different levels of stability. Experimental paradigms typically look at the effects of individual episodes of gratitude expression (Grant & Gino 2010). However, organizational research employing survey designs has looked at other levels of stability, such as the frequency with which gratitude is expressed within a particular relationship or organizational context (Fehr et al. 2025). Interestingly, research has rarely considered individual differences in the tendency to express gratitude. However, it would be theoretically coherent to examine expressed gratitude at this level.

Unlike felt gratitude, limited research has been conducted to differentiate gratitude expressions from related constructs. In a pilot study, Percival & Pulford (2020) found that expressions of gratitude also were perceived to be high on politeness, but expressions of politeness were less likely to be perceived to be high on gratitude. Scholars also have argued that it might be fruitful to differentiate between expressions of gratitude and expressions of appreciation (Locklear et al. 2023). However, measures of gratitude expression tend to use both terms (e.g., Ritzenhöfer et al. 2019), and past research attempting to differentiate trait gratitude and appreciation found that the terms load together in factor analyses (Wood et al. 2008). Coupled with the complexities of translation when work is done across cultural contexts, a focus on distinguishing between expressions of gratitude and expressions of appreciation risks muddying the waters more than clarifying them. In contrast, several studies have engaged in productive discussions about the specific content of gratitude expressions, with promising findings. For instance, Algoe et al. (2020) convincingly demonstrated that gratitude expressions can be differentially effective depending on what is said. In their case, the authors showed that gratitude emphasizing the virtue of the benefactor is received more positively than gratitude emphasizing the impact on the beneficiary.

Collective Gratitude Defined

Having reviewed the conceptualizations of felt and expressed gratitude at the individual level—where research attention has focused—we now turn to gratitude at higher levels of analysis. Multilevel models of emotion have long acknowledged the benefits of considering what it means for emotions to arise at higher levels of analysis (Ashkanasy & Dorris 2017). In the broader emotions literature, higher-level instantiations of emotions have taken on many forms. This includes conceptualizations of emotion as a dimension of an organization's climate or culture (Hartmann et al. 2021), a team norm (Van Kleef & Fischer 2016), or a display rule (Christoforou & Ashforth 2015), to name a few. In each case, scholars have used a multilevel lens to explore the multifaceted ways in which emotions can shape how employees perceive and act within their organizations (Ashkanasy & Dorris 2017).

Gratitude research has left these conceptualizations relatively unexplored. A theory paper by Fehr et al. (2017) argued for the importance of collective gratitude for organizations and defined collective gratitude as persistent gratitude that is shared by the members of an organization. Early

research shows that groups can indeed develop shared norms around felt gratitude, emerging through a reciprocal process wherein individual team members' gratitude shapes team felt gratitude norms, and vice versa (Delvaux et al. 2015). In a particularly compelling set of experiments, Pillay et al. (2020) utilized a gratitude induction paradigm to explore the effects of shared felt gratitude on team creativity. They found that collective felt gratitude improves team creativity by facilitating improved information elaboration. Specifically, when compared to a general positive emotion induction, gratitude appears to facilitate high-quality conversations as opposed to more surface-level discussions.

Locklear et al. (2021) shed light on precisely how collective gratitude shapes individual experiences with gratitude, demonstrating that perceptions of gratitude as a collective norm strengthen the impact of grateful emotion induction interventions. Conceptually, the distinction between group-level felt gratitude and norms regarding the feeling, expression, and interpretation of gratitude should be clarified, and their influence on each other provides an interesting avenue for further investigation. Future scholars will benefit from drawing on the broader multilevel emotion literature, such as the literatures on emotional contagion (Barsade 2002) and emotion cultures (Hartmann et al. 2021), and by considering how collective gratitude operates at both the team and organizational levels, as illustrated in **Figure 1**.

Gratitude Conceptualized and Defined: Implications for Organizations

Outside of the organizational literature, gratitude has mostly been conceptualized as an emotion at the individual level. As organizational research on gratitude expands, scholars stand to make a substantial contribution by expanding these conceptualizations. Looking first at social cascades, organizational scholars would benefit from a sustained focus on how gratitude is expressed, received, and observed. This includes an acknowledgment that these three experiences do not necessarily converge. In information-rich organizations where employees constantly engage in sensemaking and seek to understand noisy, ambiguous environments, the experiences of expressers, recipients, and observers can each be subject to unique factors that result in divergent experiences. Increased research on precisely what constitutes an expression of gratitude in organizations and how various verbal and nonverbal gestures shape perceptions that gratitude has been offered could prove highly impactful.

Per **Figure 1**, there is likewise a need for research to move along the vertical axis and consider gratitude's collective emergence at the team and organizational levels. This includes a need to study not only group norms but also how different forms of gratitude are distributed within collectives (Harrison & Klein 2007). In particular, research is sorely needed to understand how collective gratitude is expressed, received, and observed. Beyond convergence, examining the divergence of felt gratitude and gratitude expressions can provide insights into how such differences impact both individuals' gratitude experience and broader group processes.

THEORIES OF AND FOR GRATITUDE

Gratitude scholars have employed a range of theories to facilitate the conceptualization of gratitude and build a deeper understanding of its nomological net. At the turn of the twenty-first century, McCullough's et al. (2001) moral affect model played a foundational role in our understanding of felt gratitude, positioning gratitude as an affective phenomenon that serves three functions: moral barometer, moral motive, and moral reinforcer. Perhaps the most widely utilized and informative theory of gratitude, however, is the find-remind-bind model. Developed by Sara B. Algoe (2012), this theory argues that gratitude has three functions. First, it helps people find someone to attach to. Second, gratitude reminds them of the value of their partners. Third,

gratitude binds them to their partners. Find-remind-bind theory draws from the broaden-and-build theory of positive emotion (Fredrickson 2001) and, more generally, the social functionalist perspective of emotions (Keltner & Haidt 1999), which focuses on the evolutionary utility of our emotions (McCullough et al. 2008). Also of note is organizational scholars' utilization of affective events theory, usually to describe how individuals respond to received benefits and how the resulting grateful emotions act as information about the relational structure of the organizational environment (Weiss & Cropanzano 1996). While find-remind-bind is the most frequently used theory for felt gratitude, others have been used as well. In one notable study, a gratitude intervention was shown to predict employee behavior via self-control, suggesting that felt gratitude is impactful in part because it builds employees' energetic resources (Locklear et al. 2021).

Turning to expressed gratitude, choices of relevant theories depend in part on whether the focus is on the receipt of gratitude or its expression. Looking first to the receipt of gratitude, the EASI model (Van Kleef 2009) plays an important role. The EASI model argues that emotion expressions impact recipient outcomes through two pathways: affective and cognitive. Researchers have employed this model to explore a range of outcomes of gratitude (e.g., Algie et al. 2020, Belkin & Kong 2018). As with felt gratitude, scholars also have looked at received gratitude through the lens of resource availability. As an example, one study of employee-leader relationships utilized conservation of resources theory and demonstrated a link between employees' gratitude expressions and leaders' energy (Sheridan & Ambrose 2022). Related research utilizing the work-home resources model again emphasizes the role of received gratitude in facilitating energetic resource availability (Tang et al. 2022).

Theory on the decision to express gratitude, on the other hand, is in a nascent stage. Arguments for when employees opt to express gratitude are often implicitly arguments for when employees feel gratitude. For example, Lee et al. (2019) developed a compelling model arguing that gratitude expression is most likely to result from help that does not violate beneficiaries' needs for competence and autonomy. We can thus similarly infer that attribution theories used to explore when employees feel gratitude, such as those considering the benefactor's intention or the nature of the help provided, could be utilized to examine when employees express gratitude (Sun et al. 2019). However, there is also room to develop theory around when employees might withhold expressions of the gratitude they feel or express gratitude they do not feel.

Changing focus from the intended recipient of a gratitude expression to third-party observers, one paper developed the theory of a witnessing effect whereby an observed gratitude expression is theorized to facilitate prosocial behavior toward the expresser (Algie et al. 2020). Research conducted in the organizational context has shown such observer effects to be at least partly contingent on the context surrounding the gratitude expression, with perceptions of recipient deservingness playing a significant role in how an expresser is perceived (Fehr et al. 2025). Together, these papers show that (a) gratitude expressions can have a meaningful impact beyond the beneficiary-benefactor dyad and (b) new theory is needed to unpack these dynamics.

Attributions also shape third-party perceptions. Emerging research on gratitude expressions suggests that they may be particularly sensitive to considerations of attribution and justice. For example, when witnessing an employee express gratitude to a shared leader, observing employees care about how much the leader deserved the gratitude expression (Fehr et al. 2025). Thus, attribution theory (Kelley 1967) and theories of justice, equity, and exchange (Blau 1964) offer promising intersections with the gratitude expression literature. Also of note is responsibility exchange theory, a new theory of the costs and benefits of communication strategies that explicitly integrates gratitude expression in its theorizing (Chaudhry & Loewenstein 2019). Overall, however, the relative dearth of gratitude expression research is reflected in a relatively narrow set of theories used to probe its nomological net.

Research on collective gratitude is least developed, as is its associated theory. Consistent with our model, theorizing on collective gratitude would ideally draw on multilevel theory (Rousseau 1985). In this spirit, Fehr et al. (2017) conceptualized collective gratitude as a bottom-up process that emerges from a lower level of analysis. In Pillay et al.'s (2020) research on team gratitude, they highlighted simultaneous top-down and bottom-up processes for gratitude to emerge at the group level. This area presents a frontier of theorizing with strong potential.

Theories of and for Gratitude: Implications for Organizational Research

The set of theories that organizational scholars have leveraged in our understanding of gratitude is relatively narrow. Find-remind-bind theory offers an excellent starting point, but organizational scholars would do well to build theory that explicitly keeps the organizational context in mind and moves closer to the top and right quadrants of **Figure 1** to further theorize collective gratitude across social cascades. For example, how gratitude is felt and expressed in relationships with power differentials and between organizations and individuals may differ from how gratitude manifests in friendships or romantic relationships. Moreover, while general theories of multilevel emergence might work well in the nascent stages of multilevel gratitude research, more tailored theories will likely be needed as scholars develop more nuanced models of how gratitude develops across levels and across time. More generally, scholars should leverage theories that speak to gratitude yet have not been extensively discussed in the organizational sciences and build new theory to help scholars identify the unique nuances of gratitude within organizations. For example, responsibility exchange theory argues that gratitude may involve a trade-off in the perceived warmth and competence of the expresser, suggesting valuable avenues for future research on how employees might be able to express gratitude without a competence penalty (Chaudhry & Loewenstein 2019). Opportunities exist to tailor these theories to particular instantiations of gratitude and integrate gratitude's different forms.

GRATITUDE'S FUNCTIONS

Philosophical traditions often emphasize gratitude's inherent moral value, arguing that gratitude is reflective of a person's moral character or exploring its alignment with Aristotelian notions of a good life (Leithart 2014). The social sciences, for their part, have focused less on normative discussions of gratitude and more on descriptive discussions. In other words, the emphasis is less on gratitude as a virtue and more on gratitude's nomological net. Here, we follow this line of inquiry with a focus on gratitude's impact on organizations. This allows us to begin with a consideration of why we should care about gratitude in organizations, consistent with functionalist models of emotions writ large (Keltner & Haidt 1999).

Functions of Felt Gratitude

Research on felt gratitude has primarily focused on how it impacts the emotions, cognitions, motivations, and behaviors of the person who feels grateful. Reflecting the broader psychological literature (Ma et al. 2017), perhaps the single most robust finding in the organizational sciences is that gratitude facilitates helping behavior. This finding has been demonstrated in diary studies (Sawyer et al. 2022) and field studies (Liao et al. 2023), and across cultures and different targets of one's gratitude [e.g., coworkers (Spence et al. 2014) and organizations (Ford et al. 2018)]. One study found that grateful emotions' effects on helping behavior extend to unrelated third parties, even when the helping is costly (Bartlett & DeSteno 2006). Thus, for instance, gratitude toward one's leader can be theorized to have a spillover effect, facilitating helping behavior toward coworkers or other stakeholders.

Beyond helping behavior, a robust literature attests to felt gratitude's other affiliative effects. For example, felt gratitude has been linked to heartfelt hand gestures (Farley et al. 2021), gift giving (Kini et al. 2016), efforts to directly reciprocate a benefactor's actions (Algoe & Haidt 2009), and favorable customer ratings of employees (Li et al. 2022). In a particularly interesting set of studies, felt gratitude was shown to reduce individuals' tendency to take from a pot of shared, finite resources, highlighting the extent to which felt gratitude can reorient individuals' mental models of their relationships (Kates & DeSteno 2021). Gratitude also facilitates responsiveness, a relational variable that has evaded attention in the organizational sciences yet that is an important marker of high-quality, lasting relationships (Gordon et al. 2012). Gratitude even propels behavior mimicry, highlighting the breadth of its relational impact (Jia et al. 2015). At the opposite end of the spectrum, felt gratitude reduces antisocial behaviors in the workplace, such as incivility and ostracism (Locklear et al. 2021). It also reduces the tendency to act competitively (Sasaki et al. 2020) and even reduces the tendency to more generally engage in unethical behavior such as cheating (DeSteno et al. 2019).

Numerous studies have aimed to expand our understanding of gratitude's affiliative effects by examining proximal motivations and cognitions. For example, felt gratitude has been shown to predict increased helping behavior and reduced antisocial behavior via prosocial motivations (Sawyer et al. 2022). Research suggests that gratitude's affiliative effects also can arise via perceptual shifts, such as increased trust in others (Dunn & Schweitzer 2005) and shifts in the perceived status of benefactors (Ouyang et al. 2018). More broadly, research has shown that felt gratitude shifts how people view themselves in relation to the world around them, leading them to exhibit, for instance, greater humility (Li et al. 2022) and increased patience (DeSteno et al. 2014). The evidence from Li et al. (2022) is particularly compelling, indicating that the impact of leaders' gratitude on their humility ultimately impacts team members' willingness to voice their concerns to the leader and, in turn, team innovation.

Outside of the workplace, gratitude has been shown to have a distinct effect on various markers of well-being. For example, gratitude induction procedures have been shown to reduce negative affect and improve positive affect (Layous et al. 2023). Gratitude also has been shown to protect against stress and depression, improving outcomes such as sleep quality (Boggiss et al. 2020), happiness, and life satisfaction (Toepfer et al. 2012). This points to the interesting fact that gratitude seems particularly impactful in times of acute stress and challenge, and it may be a useful coping mechanism and even a key for post-traumatic growth (Wood et al. 2010).

A handful of studies have examined the impact of gratitude when directed toward one's organization or job. Gratitude directed toward the broader organization has been linked to feelings of embeddedness in the organization and decreased turnover (Ng 2016). Gratitude for one's job has, in turn, been shown to improve employees' job satisfaction (Bianchi 2013). These findings highlight the importance of considering the referent of one's gratitude.

Finally, it is worth noting that felt gratitude's social effects may become more complex as scholars' focus moves beyond the dyad. In a study of particular relevance to organizations, a gratitude induction was shown to increase third-party punishment when the third party was seen acting unfairly (Vayness et al. 2020). This suggests that gratitude might prime attentiveness to affiliative behavior in general, in turn impacting organizations' broader social milieus.

Functions of Expressed Gratitude

With expressed gratitude, new consequences emerge. Most research has focused on received gratitude—how gratitude expressions impact their recipients. Tang et al. (2022) found that gratitude can be energizing, such that when employees feel that customers are grateful for them, they experience more relational energy, especially when they identify strongly with their jobs.

This moderated finding is important, as it highlights the role employees' conceptions of their jobs might play in the consequences of receiving gratitude at work. When we receive gratitude, we experience greater feelings of self-efficacy and social worth, thus motivating prosocial behavior (Grant & Gino 2010). Received gratitude is also energizing for leaders, with implications for a range of distal outcomes, such as leaders' satisfaction with their lives and work (Sheridan & Ambrose 2022). Research suggests that received gratitude also can buffer against unfairness (Gordon et al. 2022) and diminished social worth when one's advice is rejected or when one receives feedback that threatens their sense of competency (Cho & Fast 2012, Belkin & Kong 2018) and mitigate the negative effects of insecure attachment on relationship satisfaction (Park et al. 2019). Lastly, it is worth noting that gratitude has been shown to have spillover effects between home and work (Hu et al. 2024), including greater family satisfaction among the spouses of the employees who perceived greater gratitude (Tang et al. 2022). Given the many psychological benefits of received gratitude, it is perhaps no surprise that received gratitude has been linked to markers of physiological well-being, such as cardiovascular health (Auer et al. 2024).

The question of how gratitude expression impacts the expressers themselves represents an important yet underexamined avenue of research. Most notable is a recent mixed-methods study by Jazaieri & O'Neill (2025) that included rich qualitative data on gratitude expressions from the email listserv of a hospital's intensive care unit (ICU). The researchers found that gratitude expressions play an emotional regulation function not only for the recipients but also for the expressers, as evidenced by more positive affect and less negative affect in both recipients and expressers. Interestingly, their study found that the timing of gratitude expression matters, such that gratitude expression in anticipation of a distressing time (i.e., thanking in advance) facilitated better emotional regulation than gratitude expression in response to a distressing time (i.e., thanking post hoc). In addition, research by Algoe et al. (2013) found that relational growth with the expresser is facilitated following the receipt of a gratitude expression, and Lambert et al. (2010) found that the act of expressing gratitude has a positive impact on the communal strength of the relationship. This suggests that gratitude's binding effects stem from shifts in how both the expresser and the recipient view and act within the relationship.

Beyond work and relationships, expressions of gratitude also have been found to improve the psychological well-being of expressers themselves. For instance, writing letters of gratitude increases expressers' happiness and life satisfaction and lowers depression (Toepfer et al. 2012). A study by Seligman et al. (2005) found similar results—those who wrote and delivered a thank-you letter experienced more happiness and fewer depressive symptoms, and these benefits lasted for a month. However, a meta-analysis by Kirca et al. (2023) revealed mixed findings on the relationship between expressed gratitude and the expresser's psychological well-being. Future exploration of boundary conditions can help shed light on the most effective ways to express gratitude.

Moving beyond the recipient and expresser, Algoe et al. (2020) published particularly intriguing work on the witnessing effect, showing that expressions of gratitude facilitate affiliative behavior between expressers and observers. In Jazaieri & O'Neill's (2025) study of ICU employees, they noted how those who were neither the recipient nor expresser of gratitude but witnessed gratitude expressed via reply-all emails were similarly encouraged to be resilient during challenging periods of work. Vayness et al. (2020) found that gratitude increases third-party punishment because of a strengthened sense of fairness, while Fehr et al. (2025) found that gratitude impacts the extent to which observers view the expresser as being prosocial, contingent on perceived deservingness. Conversely, experimental work has found that when a person is perceived to hold back expressions of gratitude, onlookers become decreasingly motivated to interact with them (Manokara et al. 2024).

Downsides of Felt and Expressed Gratitude

Although the consequences of felt and expressed gratitude are overwhelmingly positive, some potential downsides have also been demonstrated. Outside of organizations, scholars have noted that gratitude could cause problems for those who feel it, such as if it traps a person in an abusive relationship (Wood et al. 2016), causes a person to feel committed to an unethical benefactor (Zhu et al. 2020), or causes them to go too far in foregoing their personal interests (Kong & Belkin 2019). Cross-cultural research shows that gratitude expression can convey distance from another person as it sets the parameters of relationship expectations and signals that the benefits exceed those expectations (Yu & Chaudhry 2024). Laurin et al. (2025) found that excessive gratitude expression can reduce perceptions of the expresser's status, highlighting the importance of considering gratitude expressions' frequency. In an interesting marketing study, Liu et al. (2015) showed that the effects of gratitude can be weakened when paired with financial expressions of appreciation. Similarly, felt gratitude's beneficial effects appear to wane when gratitude is explicitly used as a tool to obtain a positive outcome (Weidman & Kross 2021). This is an example of the challenges that arise when gratitude is juxtaposed against a transactional workplace context. Bringing gratitude into the workplace is unlikely to be so simple as a corporate mandate. Thus, an appreciation of its nuances and risks is essential.

Functions of Collective Gratitude

Empirical research on collective gratitude's effects has shown that team-level felt gratitude can have a top-down effect on individuals' grateful emotions and impact teams' deliberative processes (Pillay et al. 2020). Theoretical work has proposed additional consequences of collective gratitude, such as organizational resilience and corporate social responsibility (Fehr et al. 2017). Such theorizing is consistent with empirical work on other collective emotions, such as work demonstrating the effects of collective joy on workplace functioning (Hartmann et al. 2021). Relatedly, theoretical work from educational psychology suggests that group gratitude interventions may be more effective than individual or dyadic ones as they provide more opportunities for people to give, receive, and observe gratitude (Wong et al. 2024). The researchers propose that when gratitude interventions for collectives create multiple opportunities for group members to express, receive, and observe gratitude, gratitude is cultivated via various interpersonal learning mechanisms and leads to improved relationships and well-being for members. Applying the same logic to workplaces, collective gratitude interventions may similarly lead to more positive outcomes for employees than individual/dyadic ones due to built-in opportunities to practice, learn, and experience gratitude. However, the consequences of collective gratitude remain mostly unexplored.

Functions of Gratitude: Implications for Organizational Research

The vast majority of the literature to date has focused on gratitude's effects on helping behavior and other affiliative acts. Organizational scholars have made important strides in looking beyond these outcomes, exploring gratitude's implications for important workplace phenomena such as creativity and turnover. Future scholarship would benefit from continuing to look beyond helping and affiliative behaviors, by either continuing to explore other organizationally relevant outcomes or exploring organizationally relevant contingencies and nuances of more established effects. Turning to **Figure 1**, scholars would do well to move toward the less explored quadrants, by exploring either the cascading social effects of gratitude, its effects at higher levels of analysis, or both. To the right side of the figure, there is much to be gained by probing how gratitude shapes observer experiences, especially during high-visibility times, such as company meetings. Moving to the top of the figure, there is likewise much to be gained by exploring how gratitude exerts an

influence at the team and organizational levels. Finally, it is notable that while research has been conducted within many different cultures, research explicitly aiming to account for cross-cultural differences in gratitude's functions is sparse. As a result, there is little research available to guide scholars seeking to understand how they might tailor their expectations of gratitude's effects to a particular cultural context.

GRATITUDE'S ANTECEDENTS

Having discussed the unique functions of gratitude in organizations, we next turn our attention to gratitude's antecedents. We first consider the antecedents of felt gratitude, followed by expressed and collective gratitude.

Antecedents of Felt Gratitude

Psychological models of felt gratitude identify received help as its primary cause (McCullough et al. 2001). This is generally the case in the organizational sciences as well (Locklear et al. 2023). Scholars have added many important nuances to this finding, largely focused on beneficiaries' interpretations of the antecedent act of helping. For example, help is particularly likely to elicit felt gratitude when the help itself is seen as instrumental to the beneficiary's goals (Converse & Fishbach 2012). As another example, reactive help has been shown to elicit stronger feelings of gratitude than proactive help, a finding that the authors theorize is partly because reactive help better meets beneficiaries' needs (Lee et al. 2019). As another example, acts of verbal help are most likely to elicit gratitude when they are linguistically synchronous with beneficiaries' own words, in part because such synchrony predicts the perceived effectiveness of the help (Doré & Morris 2018).

Beyond these findings on perceptions of benefactors' helpfulness, research on mindfulness as an antecedent of felt gratitude suggests that gratitude is also facilitated by individual variations in attentiveness to received help (Sawyer et al. 2022). These findings are consistent with intervention research that has focused on reflective practice (Hu et al. 2024). The findings also dovetail with research demonstrating that we often fail to see the sacrifices other people make for us, to the detriment of our felt gratitude (Visserman et al. 2019).

In a particularly interesting study, Chow & Lowery (2010) found that gratitude emerges only when beneficiaries feel that they are also at least partly responsible for their own outcomes. Beyond interpretations of the help itself, felt gratitude hinges on how beneficiaries perceive the motives of the benefactor and their relationship with the benefactor. One study, for example, shows that felt gratitude emerges when the beneficiary believes the benefactor acted autonomously and for prosocial reasons (Kim et al. 2018).

Another key theme to emerge from extant work on felt gratitude is the importance of the benefactor-beneficiary relationship. For example, Liao et al. (2023) showed that gratitude emerges most readily when employees receive more help than they give, but also when both parties give at a high level despite the imbalance. Another found that gratitude emerges at the intersection of servant leadership and relational attributions—when the leader acts prosocially, and the employee believes that the prosociality resulted from the quality of the employee-leader relationship (Sun et al. 2019). Additional research has highlighted the impact of gender match between the benefactor and beneficiary, suggesting that social comparison orientation plays a central role (Guarana et al. 2017). In a particularly rigorous and well-crafted study, Forster et al. (2022) showed in a competitive test of 10 different information-processing models that the primary predictor of felt gratitude is the change in social valuation of a benefactor from Time 1 to Time 2. This brings the interesting implication that people may habituate to the help they receive, presenting a challenge for organizations seeking to build cultures of gratitude.

Turning to forms of felt gratitude that reference a job or organization, employees tend to be most grateful for their jobs when they are obtained during an economic recession (Bianchi 2013) and most grateful for their organizations when they feel respected (Ng 2016). Similar to past research on displaced emotions [e.g., aggression (Hoobler & Brass 2006)], a study by Ford et al. (2018) found that supervisor actions in the form of respectful interactions facilitate employees' gratitude toward the organization, given that supervisors are the most prominent organizational agents that embody the organization in the eyes of the employee.

Research on the inhibitors of felt gratitude is less developed but promising. Of note is the finding that narcissism and cynicism are particularly detrimental to gratitude (Solom et al. 2017). Further, Watkins (2014) theorized that feelings of suspicion and envy might inhibit gratitude by altering perceptions of others' motives and advantages. These findings may pertain to organizations as well, where social comparison is commonplace.

Antecedents of Expressed Gratitude

Among studies that examine gratitude expression, more focus on gratitude expressions' consequences than their antecedents. Nonetheless, there is a sufficient body of literature to identify trends and opportunities. A significant proportion of studies focus on factors that could be said to precede both expressed gratitude and felt gratitude. Early research, for instance, linked gratitude expression to the significance of the received help (Okamoto & Robinson 1997), mirroring findings in the literature on felt gratitude. The most interesting studies on expressed gratitude, however, focus on factors unique to gratitude expression. One study, for example, found that beneficiaries may be hesitant to translate their grateful feelings into gratitude expressions because they underestimate the extent to which the benefactor will react positively to the gratitude (Kumar & Epley 2018). There also is evidence of interindividual variability in this valuation. For instance, Parker et al.'s (2017) study suggests that people with autonomous motivations value gratitude less than other people. Another study suggests that women are more likely to value and feel more comfortable with expressing gratitude as compared to men (Kashdan et al. 2009). These findings carry the implication that some employees might express gratitude or seek it from others less simply because they see less value in it. Further, Anicich et al. (2022) found that lower-power individuals express more gratitude than higher-power individuals, driven by interpersonal orientation.

At the frontier of research on expressed gratitude is work considering the antecedents of different forms of gratitude expression. Weiss et al. (2020) found that receiving an unexpected benefit facilitates other-praising gratitude expressions (e.g., "You did so much to make this happen"), while happiness with the benefit facilitates self-benefiting gratitude expressions (e.g., "This is helpful for me"), with the former being more effective for relationship building than the latter. Other studies have shown that broader contextual factors, such as culture, can influence the form that expressions of gratitude take (Chang & Algoe 2020). While research has explored the reasons a person who feels gratitude might not opt to express it, research on why a person might choose to express gratitude they do not feel is surprisingly absent from the literature.

Finally, it should be noted that gratitude expression interventions, which ask participants to engage in an act of gratitude expression, such as by writing a gratitude letter, can themselves be conceptualized as an antecedent of gratitude expression. The important lesson here is that because beneficiaries tend to be overly hesitant to express gratitude (Kumar & Epley 2018), nudges from third parties might prove one of the most effective tools for moving the needle on gratitude expression at work. Ultimately, however, a deeper exploration of employees' hesitations around gratitude expression would be beneficial.

Antecedents of Collective Gratitude

Empirical research on the antecedents of collective gratitude is scarce. Nonetheless, some knowledge can be gleaned from the existing literature. A key lesson that can be derived from the existing literature is that collective gratitude emerges both from the top down and from the bottom up. As shown by Delvaux et al. (2015), gratitude can emerge from the bottom up, such that individuals' gratitude experiences are the foundation of the emergence of collective gratitude. Multiple processes can be theorized to drive such effects, including emotion contagion when speaking to felt gratitude and social learning when speaking to expressed gratitude. For example, when gratitude expressions from individual members are observed in a team, this can facilitate social learning and the emergence of team gratitude where the emotion becomes shared. Past theorizing has noted that top-down influences, such as HR practices, also should be examined (Fehr et al. 2017). Locklear et al.'s (2021) work on perceived gratitude norms speaks to these top-down effects, as does the broader literature on emotion cultures (Hartmann et al. 2021). In a study on war commemorations, researchers found that commemorations can spark feelings of gratitude for the group's sacrifice. This offers an interesting window into how organizations might develop collective gratitude as a part of an organization's culture (Watkins & Bastian 2019).

Antecedents of Gratitude: Implications for Organizational Research

Gratitude in organizations is generally understood to develop from the benefits an employee received, whether captured in diary studies as individual acts of help or in survey studies through markers such as servant leadership. This research emphasizes a foundation of help and prosociality as essential to gratitude. At the same time, an encouraging theme of the existing literature emphasizes how even a relatively minimal intervention, such as brief daily writing in gratitude journals (Locklear et al. 2021) and recall prompts (DeSteno et al. 2014), can elicit or heighten gratitude. The consistent finding that simple gratitude inductions and interventions can effectively facilitate gratitude suggests that organizations may be able to build gratitude even with limited time and relatively thin modalities. Nonetheless, organizational scholars have much to gain from examining what happens when gratitude collides with organizations' tendencies to view relationships in transactional and competitive ways. And as with research on gratitude's consequences, research focused on gratitude's antecedents has rarely considered the moderating role of culture. This leaves open important questions about how cultural contexts might shape the paths by which leaders seek to shape employees' gratitude.

DIRECTIONS FOR FUTURE RESEARCH

In this review, we introduced a model of social cascades and multilevel emergence and utilized it as a scaffold to build a multidimensional conceptualization of gratitude. In this final section, we wrap up our review with a consideration of important frontiers for future research (also summarized in **Table 2**).

Putting the Organization in Organizational Gratitude Research

The first new frontier we identify is a need for deeper consideration of how the organizational context shapes gratitude's dynamics in the workplace. While the number of studies examining gratitude at work has flourished, much of the work that has been done could be characterized as a replication of social psychological findings in an organizational context.

Future work should make a targeted effort to focus on aspects of the organizational context that are likely to shape gratitude in understudied ways. One example is hierarchy. Much of the

Table 2 Key directions for future research

Topic area	Potential research questions
Organizational gratitude research	How does gratitude intersect with organizational power hierarchies? How might gratitude be influenced or constrained by organizational systems and bureaucracies, such as HR systems? How should organizations think about gratitude expression within the context of hybrid work and digital communication tools?
Intersections of emotions and expressions	How is gratitude's emergence and impact influenced by the presence of other emotional states? What happens when gratitude expressions are coupled with expressions of other emotions, such as anger, frustration, or anxiety? When is gratitude that is felt not expressed, and when is gratitude that is expressed not felt?
The justice and authenticity paradoxes	How might inequalities in gratitude expression create perceived injustices, and how might organizations address them? How does the content and context of a gratitude expression impact its perceived authenticity? How might impression management motives shape reactions to gratitude across levels?
Gratitude at higher levels	How might distributions of felt and expressed gratitude emerge at higher levels and shape collective outcomes? How might the effects of gratitude be influenced by contextual factors such as organizational climate and intergroup dynamics? How do groups of benefactors and beneficiaries differ from individual benefactors and beneficiaries?
Gratitude across cultures	How do the meaning and effects of gratitude vary across cultures? How do cultural values and work differences change expectations and perceptions of gratitude expression? What might a culturally sensitive model of gratitude intervention look like?
From dark to gray	What are the predominant inhibitors of gratitude's positive effects? When are cynical attributions for gratitude most likely to emerge? How might top-down directives and monitoring around gratitude impact its effectiveness, and how can these risks be mitigated?

existing psychological literature on gratitude has focused on interactions among strangers, friends, or romantic partners, offering relatively little insight into workplace hierarchy. While researchers have begun to explore gratitude within hierarchies, more work remains to be done. For example, research might benefit from considering how gratitude is differentially affected by power versus status differences or by the unique constraints of “middle power” (Anicich & Hirsh 2017, p. 659). As another example, scholars would benefit from considering how gratitude is uniquely impacted or constrained by HR practices.

As a final example, with the rise of remote and hybrid work arrangements, workplace interactions have become increasingly virtual. As such, it is now particularly important to consider the modality in which gratitude is offered. Conventional wisdom suggests that gratitude expressions are most potent when expressed in person. Yet studies also have shown gratitude to be efficacious when expressed in writing. For instance, Sheldon & Yu (2022) found that expressing gratitude via text and in person led to equally positive emotions for both the expresser and recipient. Interestingly, they also found that expressing gratitude via text instead of face-to-face was less risky and thus less embarrassing for the gratitude expresser. Similarly, in a sample of college students, Walsh et al. (2023) found that participants experienced a heightened boost in relational benefits when they expressed gratitude in the form of a personal text message (versus not sharing gratitude or sharing gratitude publicly on social media). It would be meaningful to examine such dynamics in the work context.

Intersections of Emotions and Expressions

One important direction in the conceptualization of gratitude lies in the intersection of emotions and expressions, where existing research is very sparse. We consider three versions of such intersection. First, research would benefit from considering what happens when gratitude intersects with other emotions in the workplace. What happens, for instance, when an act of help instills feelings of gratitude, but those feelings of gratitude are compounded with feelings of shame? What is the difference between gratitude coupled with activating emotions, such as excitement, and less activating emotions, such as calmness? We encourage researchers to unpack these important nuances. Incorporating theories on emotional ambivalence, in particular, could help shed light on such dual-emotion phenomena (Rothman et al. 2017).

A similar question can be asked regarding intersecting expressions. Nearly all research on gratitude expressions focuses on straightforward operationalizations, such as by manipulating gratitude in an experiment with a straightforward thank you. But what happens when gratitude expressions are coupled with expressions of other emotions, such as anger or anxiety? Would the gratitude expression still be perceived as authentic? And what happens when gratitude expressions are coupled with attributions that shift observers' sensemaking processes? In particular, gratitude expressions would likely be perceived more negatively when they are attributed to hidden agendas, such as to curry favor with one's boss. At the collective level, these possibilities raise interesting questions about how gratitude might intersect with existing cultures, climates, and norms around emotions.

Additionally, we note the value of considering potential mismatches between the experience of gratitude as an emotion and its expression. Why might employees withhold expressions of the gratitude they feel? Conversely, why might employees express gratitude they do not feel? We recommend that researchers draw on past work on emotional labor (Grandey 2000) and authenticity (Cha et al. 2019) as they further explore these unexamined issues.

The Justice and Authenticity Paradoxes

Another frontier for future research is what we term the paradoxes of justice and authenticity. First is the justice paradox, which states that employees are sensitive to who receives gratitude in the organization and who is excluded. Organizations will need to be cautious about the inequitable distribution of gratitude and consider how to ensure that some employees are not unfairly denied appreciation. It might be the case, for instance, that gratitude is particularly likely to flow as a function of propinquity or homophily rather than an individual's underlying virtues (McPherson et al. 2001). Yet research has shown that gratitude is directly linked to justice concerns as it sensitizes people to the benefits they have received, including those not made available to others (Goenka & Van Osselaer 2019). In short, gratitude and justice considerations may be more closely linked than previously assumed.

Second, as scholars establish the benefits of gratitude for organizations, there is a risk that organizations may encourage gratitude to the detriment of its perceived authenticity. It is unclear if authenticity is central to gratitude's positive effects. Indeed, past research on related phenomena, such as compliments, suggests that people are generally sufficiently eager to receive positive feedback that they are relatively insensitive to concerns about its sincerity. Nonetheless, authenticity may still loom over gratitude, particularly for gratitude initiatives and third parties' reactions to gratitude. Fascinating research by Weidman & Kross (2021) suggests that when gratitude is used as a tool, its effects dissipate due to feelings of inauthenticity.

In organizations, considerations of authenticity are vital. For instance, Wang et al. (2024) found that reminders to show gratitude can undermine gratitude expressions' impact. As leaders design these gratitude initiatives, we recommend thoughtful consideration of the implications of such initiatives for the whole group. In particular, these initiatives should ideally be inclusive

and recognize the contributions of all employees, regardless of status and roles. As such, we encourage discussions of what actions warrant appreciation, as focusing on contributions to the organizational bottom line would be vastly different from focusing on prosociality.

Looking beyond the boundaries of the organization itself, it is common for organizations to engage in impression management strategies to influence the perceptions of external stakeholders. Similar to how third parties are actively evaluating, and are influenced by, the gratitude expressions of others at the individual level (Algoe et al. 2020), there is a vast strategic management literature on the impact of various organizational impression management strategies on external parties (e.g., Bass et al. 2023). For instance, consistent gratitude expressions to long-time partner organizations could signal a strong relationship between both firms. Alternatively, an absence of sincere expressions of gratitude from a CEO who is stepping down from their role could signal a challenging transition.

Gratitude at Higher Levels

As mentioned in our introduction, research on gratitude at higher levels of analysis is sparse. Nonetheless, we can identify promising avenues for future research by looking at what we already know about gratitude and multilevel phenomena in general. A homophilous claim—one that assumes isomorphism between gratitude processes and functions at the individual and collective levels—would suggest that, to the extent that gratitude emerges at the collective level, its outcomes should be positive. But, at the group level, new complexities emerge. For instance, while one version of a culture of gratitude might involve genuine acts of appreciation, another might involve gratitude display rules that employees perceive as inauthentic and depleting. As another example, research in the teams literature might wish to differentiate gratitude within teams from gratitude across teams. Whereas these two emergent phenomena might share some antecedents [e.g., servant leadership (Sun et al. 2019)], others might differentially affect how employees act [e.g., collective narcissism (Golec de Zavala & Lantos 2020)].

A promising path for future research is to examine distributions of gratitude expression in groups, as individuals within a group may experience or express gratitude differently. If, for example, gratitude expressions are unevenly distributed in a group, impacts on group dynamics or the organization's climate and culture could emerge. Such differences may depend on the degree or type of differentiation among the group members. For example, Ksenofontov & Becker (2020) showed that when lower-power group members express gratitude for benefits from higher-power group members, it can discourage lower-power group members from voicing their dissent. Such dynamics imply that gratitude could reinforce or exacerbate power imbalances in organizations due to the system-justifying function of gratitude norms that lead individuals to self-censor criticism toward benefactors (Eibach et al. 2015).

Gratitude research also can benefit from distinguishing between the level of the benefactor and the level of the beneficiary. For example, the benefactor may be at a higher level, such as a group or an organization providing a benefit. A nonprofit organization advocating for a vulnerable stakeholder group is an example where the benefactor is at a higher level of analysis. Conversely, the beneficiary may be at a higher level, such as a group or an organization receiving benefits. An organization thanking its frontline workers presents an example where the beneficiary is at a higher level of analysis.

Gratitude Across Cultures

Studies on gratitude have been conducted across many cultures, but those explicitly examining cultural differences are rare. This is true outside the organizational literature as well, with a few exceptions. One study found that Americans are more receptive to gratitude via physical touch

than Taiwanese participants (Chang & Algoe 2020). In another study, Zhang et al. (2018) found that Chinese participants reacted more negatively to gratitude from a close other than Euro-Canadian participants, while Euro-Canadian participants reacted more negatively to not receiving gratitude from a close other after providing help than Chinese participants. These findings suggest that some cultures may perceive gratitude as a sign of formality and distance while others consider gratitude a sign of politeness. Other research has shown that, compared to the United States, gratitude is more closely associated with feelings of guilt in the United Kingdom, feelings of indebtedness in Korea, and feelings of sadness in India (Morgan et al. 2014, Oishi et al. 2019, Titova et al. 2017).

Cross-cultural differences should be considered within the context of work. It may be, for instance, that some cultures consider gratitude to be more appropriate and expected in the workplace than others based on the norms around emotional expression (e.g., Baumeister & Ilko 1995). It is similarly possible that cultural values such as humane orientation, which encourages individuals to be generous and caring, could influence gratitude expressions and perceptions (House et al. 2004). As another example, cultures might differ in the perceived appropriateness and content of leader-directed gratitude expression. These considerations are important in relation to individual expressions of gratitude as well as broader organizational initiatives.

From Dark to Gray

A growing number of studies have begun to explore gratitude's downsides. For example, research has noted that felt gratitude could lead to an escalation of commitment in relational dilemmas (Kong & Belkin 2019), while expressed gratitude could risk exploitation in negotiations (Lee et al. 2018). Another study found that gratitude for immoral behavior, such as immoral help that is offered, can have a negative reputational impact on the expresser (Yu & Chaudhry 2024). These findings suggest that some types of gratitude are viewed negatively and that individuals may benefit from being strategic about when to express or withhold gratitude.

While examinations of gratitude's downsides are important, there is a risk to overemphasizing its dark side in the name of novelty. We encourage researchers to think more broadly about what constitutes a meaningful contribution to gratitude theory. For example, while felt gratitude has been linked to engaging in third-party punishment, such behavior is presumably motivated by a desire to ensure future prosociality (Vayness et al. 2020). Simply saying that gratitude is bad might seem like a meaningful contribution due to its counterintuitiveness. However, the effects of gratitude are likely more nuanced. Rather than focusing on the dark side of gratitude, we encourage scholars to focus on what we might term its gray side—the situations under which the positive effects of gratitude become muted or otherwise shift.

An example area for future research is to consider when gratitude initiatives are likely to fall flat, such as when they are likely to be perceived as inauthentic. This follows Weidman & Kross's (2021) work on how we tend to react adversely to the use of positive emotions as a tool due to feelings of inauthenticity. As an example, an initiative focused on building feelings of gratitude through a shared journaling exercise at a company retreat might fall flat if employees perceive the exercise as driven by leaders' desire to push employees to work harder. By asking themselves when gratitude interventions are likely to fail in their purpose of inspiring felt or expressed gratitude, both academics and practitioners can make important contributions to our understanding of gratitude in the workplace.

CONCLUSION

In this review, we present a model of gratitude that examines both social cascades and collective emergence. With this model, we offer insight into how gratitude moves from an individual's

internal experience to impact relational partners and beyond. Given extensive evidence for gratitude's capacity to transform employees and their organizations, continued research on gratitude in organizations stands to make a significant and lasting contribution to the organizational sciences.

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